Understanding unfamiliar examples and references

Practical guide for students | D09-ST

An unfamiliar place, practice, expression or cultural reference can make a subject example difficult to follow. Identify the background information you need, then connect the example to the course concept.

1. Separate the concept from the setting

Ask yourself which part is unfamiliar: the subject idea, a word, or the situation used to illustrate it. You may understand the concept even if you do not know the setting.

2. Identify the missing information

Mark the specific reference and ask what you need to know to follow the explanation. Avoid spending time researching details that do not affect the learning point.

3. Ask a focused question

Try: “I’m not familiar with that system. What do we need to know about it for this example?” You can ask during a pause or use an available written question route.

4. Find the link to the subject

After clarification, explain how the example illustrates the concept. Ask: “Is the important point here that demand changes when the price changes?”

5. Try a familiar comparison

Think of a situation you know that might illustrate the same idea. Check whether the relevant conditions match; a familiar example may differ in ways that change the explanation.

6. Record the useful connection

Keep a brief note of the concept and how the example shows it. Include any important limits. Return to the original course terminology when explaining the idea.

7. Example

Your teacher uses a seasonal ski resort to explain changes in demand. You ask what makes its demand seasonal. After the teacher explains, you compare it with a beach hotel that has busy and quiet periods. You check which factors are similar and which differ before using the comparison.

8. Quick checklist

☐ I can identify the unfamiliar reference.

☐ I know which background details matter.

☐ I can explain the link to the subject concept.

☐ I have checked the limits of my comparison.

9. When to seek further support

If unfamiliar references regularly prevent you from following, show your teacher two or three examples and explain the missing context. Ask for a brief explanation or another example. You do not need to speak for a whole cultural or language group.

10.Supporting sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Group Work/Projects. Open resource

Supports asking specific questions and clarifying unfamiliar terms or meaning.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Tips for communicating with international and multilingual students. Open resource